

TREATMENT · SPORTS DRAMA

TALENT

THE RIGHT TO BE HEARD

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Taurus Digital × Neyra Vision · Almaty · 2026

ACT I

THE SOUND AND THE FURY

On the dazzling stage of the television talent show TALENT, eighteen-year-old Alex plays the dombra with virtuosity and primal passion. On the final, most powerful chord, a string snaps. The audience erupts in applause, and one of the judges, pop star Anna Prazdnik, is captivated by the drama of his performance.

Backstage, in the dressing room, Alex encounters his chief rival: Anton, a technically flawless but emotionally cold pianist.

Anton arrogantly declares that Alex's rough playing caused the string to snap, pointing out that his hands are “too rough for the dombra.”

Alex responds sharply, but Anton, impressed by his defiance, leaves him his business card.

Their paths diverge: Alex takes the tram home, while Anton drives off in his own Porsche, rudely throwing out the girls who dare to suggest that a “sugar daddy” paid for the car.

The next day, Alex's elderly, cultured music teacher, Yan Borisovich, gives him a priceless gift: a dombra made in 1720 by a great master craftsman.

A flashback reveals the deep bond between them. Six years earlier, the teacher found twelve-year-old Alex, abandoned by his father, in the school's boiler room. In tears, the boy was hammering cast-iron tanks with iron rods, unleashing incredible fury with perfect musical timing and sending the entire school into an uproar.

Recognizing a true musical gift in this destructive pain, Yan Borisovich introduces Alex to the dombra and tells him its legend. A master craftsman made the instrument in 1720 and gave it to a street musician on one condition: if the dombra failed to “make its voice heard around the world,” it must be passed on to someone who could make that happen.

Now Alex must fulfill the master's wish by playing it in the competition final.

Yan Borisovich thus passes on more than an instrument. He entrusts Alex with a legacy, just as his own teacher once entrusted it to him.

But reality deals a cruel blow to both contestants, confronting them with the tyranny of their fathers.

Over a family dinner in a luxurious mansion, powerful businessman Viktor Viktorovich gives his son Anton an ultimatum. If Anton refuses to study in London and prepare to take over the family corporation, choosing music over a multibillion inheritance, he must win the show and prove his right to pursue music. Otherwise, his father will immediately cut off all financial support and send him into the army instead of to a prestigious institution in London. Anton rebels, choosing his own path.

When Alex wakes the following morning in his modest apartment, he discovers that the instrument is missing.

His father Nikolai, a former boxing coach who has succumbed to alcoholism, admits that he has pawned it, cynically tossing his son a crumpled five-thousand-tenge note.

Alex races to the pawnshop, but the cold-blooded pawnbroker demands one hundred thousand tenge to redeem the dombra before closing time. He is awaiting an expert appraiser's verdict.

Outside, with the proceeds of the sale in his pocket, Alex's father runs into Yan Borisovich. Spitting cherry pits directly at him, Nikolai, consumed by hatred and jealousy toward the teacher, declares that there is “a beast” inside Alex that will inevitably defeat the music, and that strumming strings is no occupation for a man.

Events gather momentum. Penniless after his father freezes his accounts, Anton finds a despondent Alex at an outdoor sports ground.

The pianist knows the dombra player's secret: as a child, Alex was an unbeatable knockout boxer nicknamed “The Beast.” Videos of his knockouts are all over the internet.

Anton proposes a desperate deal and takes Alex to an underground hardcore bare-knuckle fight club run by a ruthless promoter called Razor.

To raise the money to redeem his instrument, Alex enters the cage in his everyday clothes and knocks a professional fighter unconscious with a single lightning-fast, devastating counterpunch.

Taking his share, five hundred thousand tenge, Alex promises Anton that he will never fight again.

As Alex rushes to the pawnshop, an expert in a laboratory confirms to the pawnbroker, his voice trembling with excitement, that the artifact is authentic.

Alex reaches the doors, but the pawnshop has already closed.

Through the display window, he sees his dombra with a new, devastating price tag: 60,000,000 Kazakh tenge.

In a fit of helpless rage and despair, the musician smashes his fists against the reinforced glass, mangling his hands as the alarm howls.

At home, washing the blood from his battered fists, Alex hears a television announcement for Razor's new bare-knuckle tournament. The grand prize is exactly 60,000,000 Kazakh tenge.

The next morning, the two return to the hardcore fight club. Anton assumes the role of a ruthless agent, taking a percentage of any future prize money.

Having secured Alex's place in Razor's bare-knuckle tournament, Anton plans to repair his own finances: his father has blocked all his accounts.

At the fighters' first press conference, Alex coolly and brazenly provokes the favorite, a fighter nicknamed “Tractor Driver,” forcing an immediate bout.

In the cage, Tractor Driver knocks Alex down, but the musician unleashes his inner beast and brutally knocks his opponent out.

Amid the deafening roar of the crowd chanting his new name, “TALENT,” Alex stands with his arm raised, looks toward Anton in the audience, and says just one thing:

> *“I need to start training again.”*

ACT II

THE RIFT

A DOUBLE LIFE AND THE COST OF LIES

The second act opens with Alex visiting Yan Borisovich after his first underground fight. The teacher notices that the young man's hands are stiff, that his playing has lost its voice, and asks him outright whether he has been fighting. Alex evades the question, referring only to “training.”

The key moment of tension comes when Yan Borisovich asks why Alex has not brought the dombra. Alex is forced to lie, claiming that he simply “forgot” it at home. The teacher demands that Alex decide what matters more to him.

THE OLD GARAGE

Alex unlocks a rusty padlock.

Inside is a garage converted into a gym, covered in dust and cobwebs. Trophies stand on the shelves beside faded newspaper clippings about a young, undefeated champion.

Nearby are photographs of his victories: Alex wearing medals and championship belts, with his father and coach beside him, still happy and proud.

Without a word, Alex begins clearing out the garage, getting it ready for training.

Meanwhile, Anton's crisis deepens. He is Alex's direct rival in the TALENT final. With his accounts frozen and forced to choose between his father's corporation in London and the army, Anton becomes Alex's fight agent for a selfish reason: to make money off him.

Anton tells Alex bluntly that he will never beat him at music. But together, they can make good money.

Alex's family is also divided. His mother learns that his father has sold the priceless instrument and tearfully realizes that her son will fight again to buy it back.

His father tries to recover the dombra by force, trashes the pawnshop, and is taken into police custody.

After getting him released, Alex's mother demands that he leave them for good.

Nikolai comes to the old garage, where Alex is training alone, without a coach. A furious sparring match erupts between them: father and son settle their grievances in boxing gloves.

The roots of their conflict lie in a tragedy six years earlier. At twelve, Alex was a phenomenon, an undefeated fighter nicknamed “The Beast.”

Sponsors paid for him to travel to the world championship in Brazil, but the night before departure Nikolai got drunk with the other coaches at the gym, celebrating his son's success.

The next morning, after the plane had already left, his drunken father returned home and said:

> *“And here's our champion.”*

For Alex, this was an act of absolute betrayal. His father had destroyed his dream with his own hands. That day, the boy threw his boxing gloves at Nikolai's feet and left home.

Later, Alex met Yan Borisovich, who used music to help heal his soul and reveal his true talent.

Since then, Alex has stopped seeing Nikolai as a father. To him, Nikolai is the coach who betrayed him: a man who once destroyed his future, only to do it again years later by selling the dombra for another bottle on the eve of his most important performance, the final.

Alex says bitterly:

> *“I did everything my coach told me. But did I ever have a father?”*

Nikolai, too, lives with his own pain. He devoted his life to his son, training him to become a champion from the age of three and finding the meaning of his own existence in Alex's victories. When Alex abandoned sport and chose music, his father saw it as a betrayal of every sacrifice he had made and every hope he had held. To Nikolai, music represents weakness and a rejection of the fighter's path.

Their confrontation becomes more than a family drama. It is a collision between two worlds: strength and talent, rigid control and freedom of choice.

The conflict ends with Nikolai becoming Alex's coach again, preparing him for the bare-knuckle tournament.

Alex's life splits in two. In the garage, he drills punches relentlessly with his father; in his teacher's apartment, he tries to play music.

The lies multiply. Yan Borisovich suffers a medical episode, and when Alex visits him with an ordinary instrument, the teacher asks why he is not rehearsing on the one he was given.

Alex lies, saying he left the dombra at home to avoid carrying it around.

Yan Borisovich senses that something is wrong.

“Are you lying to me?”

But Alex continues to hide the fact that the dombra is in the pawnshop.

The punishing training damages Alex's hands. During rehearsals, a horrified Yan Borisovich stops him, shouting that he is “hammering” the dombra.

A LOVE TRIANGLE AND A RIVAL'S JEALOUSY

Anna Prazdnik brings Alex into a musical duet. During rehearsal, passion flares between them.

Watching from the darkened auditorium is Anton, who previously proposed to Anna, giving her a ring and an apartment, only to be rejected. Spurned and deprived of his father's money, Anton burns with jealousy toward his chief rival in the show.

MIDPOINT: A DOUBLE BLOW AND THE TRUTH EXPOSED

The television semifinal arrives alongside decisive bouts in the cage.

Intercut sequences show Alex playing on the television stage with his eyes closed and fighting brutally against a wrestler named Isa in the hardcore club. Alex wins on both fronts, receiving an unequivocal “Yes” from Anna on the judging panel.

Afterward, Alex visits Yan Borisovich with bloodied knuckles. Seeing his mangled hands, the teacher cries:

“Stop!”

He delivers his final ultimatum:

“Either music or brawling.”

Hands like these cannot give music a voice. Alex leaves in silence.

Having lost his mentors' support, Alex seeks refuge with Anna. After she helps him overcome his fear of heights on a Ferris wheel, they spend a passionate night together.

The next morning, a drunken Anton finds them together and leaves, utterly broken.

The lies reach their breaking point and strike the most vulnerable person. Passing the pawnshop by chance, Yan Borisovich sees the dombra in the window, priced at sixty million Kazakh tenge.

The pieces fall into place. He realizes that Alex has been lying to him all along and is destroying his own hands in the ring to buy the instrument back.

The old man's heart cannot take it. He collapses onto the pavement with a heart attack.

The second act ends when Alex rings his teacher's doorbell and learns the terrible truth from a neighbor: Yan Borisovich is in hospital.

ACT III

REDEMPTION

Alex enters Yan Borisovich's hospital room.

The teacher turns away from him, declaring that his hands now carry pain instead of music, and that he has betrayed his soul by selling the ancient dombra.

Detached, with the icy gaze of a samurai, Alex leaves for the tournament.

Meanwhile, unable to forgive Alex's relationship with Anna and determined to eliminate his rival at any cost, Anton pays Razor to keep Alex's father out of his corner and have a merciless fighter nicknamed “The Bull” deliberately injure Alex's hands during the bout.

Denied access to the arena, Alex's father finally understands the full weight of what he has done.

He realizes that his son will be alone. There will not even be anyone in his corner to throw in the towel at the right moment and spare him lasting injury.

Nikolai rushes to Yan Borisovich in hospital and desperately confesses that he was the one who sold the dombra.

He begs the old man not to die: his son is stepping into the octagon at this very moment, utterly alone, to fight for that instrument.

At the hardcore arena, blood is running hot.

Alex flatly refuses Razor's exploitative nine-fight contract. Razor threatens him: he will never survive against The Bull, and all his friends, even his father, have betrayed him. His corner will be empty.

Suddenly, Yan Borisovich appears in the dressing room carrying a bucket and a towel. He has come to be his pupil's cornerman, to the astonishment of both Razor and Alex.

The fight for survival begins.

Against Thai boxer Varan and the powerful wrestler Maga, Alex draws on more than rage. He uses his impeccable sense of rhythm, synchronizing his breathing with his opponent, finding the timing, and knocking each man out cold as the crowd roars:

“TALENT!”

Between bouts, his fists battered, Alex writes a composition in his music notebook: in the television final, every contestant must perform a piece of their own.

Meanwhile, The Bull pounds his opponents into the canvas with exceptional brutality, clearing his path to the final.

Before the main bout, Anna Prazdnik pushes through to Alex.

She brings him a tuxedo and tearfully begs him to stop, offering the money to redeem the dombra.

The bell sounds for the final.

The enormous Bull methodically hammers Alex into the floor, deliberately trying to crush his hands.

A horrified Yan Borisovich is about to throw in the towel. Instead, he begins beating his palms against the cage, reproducing the same complex, furious rhythm from the school boiler room.

The sound triggers a flashback. Alex gets to his feet and unleashes a devastating combination on The Bull.

The giant freezes, knocked out on his feet.

The crowd and Razor hunger for blood, demanding that Alex finish him off. But Alex holds on to his humanity: he simply raises his fist in victory.

The Bull collapses, and Alex takes a bag containing ten million.

Every minute counts. While the show's producer threatens to fire Anna if Alex wins, the bloodied musician pulls the tuxedo over his battered body.

He and Yan Borisovich race to the pawnshop in an old Moskvich that keeps stalling.

The pawnbroker, who has made a fortune betting on Alex, magnanimously returns the dombra for sixty million Kazakh tenge earned in blood.

Arriving at the television studio, Alex realizes that he has left behind the music notebook in which he has been writing his final composition throughout the film. Desperate, he has no idea what to play.

Yan Borisovich tells him:

> *“You don't need the notebook. If you're going out there to give your music a voice, go and play what you've lived through. What you want to tell the world. That's what it means to find your true voice.”*

Alex silently heads for the stage.

In the television studio, Anton performs his composition brilliantly, but with no warmth at all.

Then Alex appears backstage.

The producer tries to keep him off the air because of his alarming appearance, but the broadcast's audience surges as five million bare-knuckle fight viewers tune in to watch Talent play. With the ratings soaring, the greedy producers let Alex take the stage.

His injured fingers slip off the strings, but he stubbornly begins to play.

Overcoming excruciating physical pain, Alex produces music of extraordinary sincerity and emotional depth, moving his mother and father to tears in the audience.

In the final judging, two judges choose Anton's flawless technique, while Anna gives Alex her vote and her heart. The other two cannot do otherwise: Anton's father is the television company's principal shareholder.

The deciding vote belongs to the viewers. Four million people make Alex the undisputed winner of TALENT.

In his victory speech, the champion thanks his father for teaching him not to buckle, and his music teacher for teaching him to find his voice.

Backstage comes a painful reconciliation. With tears of pride, his father shakes his son's mangled hand and asks for forgiveness.

And in the parking lot, the defeated Anton makes the most important choice of his life. He refuses his oligarch father's money, rejects a life in London, and tells his father that he chooses the army over his millions.